

A Declaration of Internet Independence

*Reclaiming the internet — its power and its rewards — into one of, by,
and for the people who use it*

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“It seems to have been reserved to the people of this country ... to decide the important question, whether societies of men are really capable or not of establishing good government from reflection and choice, or whether they are forever destined to depend for their political constitutions on accident and force.” — Alexander Hamilton (Publius), The Federalist No. 1, 1787

When the course of human life moves online — when our friendships and our work, our memory, our money, and our public square all come to live on the internet — then the terms on which that internet is owned and governed become questions of human freedom. And when those terms have, over years, been set against the very people who give the internet its life and its worth, a decent respect for one another requires that we say plainly why we mean to change them.

We hold these truths to be self-evident:

That the data each person generates is the shadow of a real life — it would not exist if that person did not — and it belongs, first and last, to them.

That the value created by the people of a network is created *by* them, and ought to flow *to* them.

That platforms, like governments, derive their just authority from the consent and the participation of those who use them.

That when a platform becomes an instrument of extraction rather than of service — taking without returning, ruling without accounting — the people who sustain it have the right, and in time the duty, to remake it, or to build in its place an internet that answers to them.

That these rights belong to no single nation, creed, or class, but to every person who lives a part of their life online.

The history of the present internet is a history of quiet expropriation — not by malice in every case, but by a structure that has, link by link and click by click, turned the many into the product and the few into its owners. To prove this, let these be submitted to a candid world:

- They have gathered the digital shadows of billions, and asked no leave, and returned no share.
- They have built vast fortunes, and now vast artificial intelligences, upon that gathered data, and have shared neither the wealth nor the say with the people whose lives that data

describes.

- They have written the rules of our common spaces in private, and changed them at will, and answered to no one but themselves.
- They have watched us without ceasing, and called the watching a service.
- They have made our attention their inventory, and our trust their leverage.
- They have gathered power over speech, commerce, and knowledge into a few unaccountable hands, beyond the reach of those that power governs.
- They have built for the next quarter what was meant to last for generations, and called the strip-mining of it growth.
- And they have taught us to call all of this normal — to click *I agree* as though we had a choice.

Set these down together and they do not describe a service. They describe a reduction: a people who should be *We the Users* have been made, click by click and link by link, into *we the used*.

No one chose this. It was built; it can be built differently.

We, therefore, the users of the internet — its readers and its writers, its makers and its menders, the people whose lives fill it — publish and declare our intent:

To build a new internet that belongs to the people who use it: where each person holds their own data; where the rewards of the network flow back to the network; and where no founder, no engineer, and no investor is set permanently above the rest.

To build it for the long horizon — to measure it not by the next quarter but by the next thousand years, on the conviction that only an internet owned by the people who use it is built to last that long.

To settle its governance not by accident, and not by force, but, in Hamilton's words, by *reflection and choice*: to write its constitution in the open, in full public view, with framers invited from among those who have given themselves to a freer and fairer digital world.

To open this work to everyone, and to make belonging a matter of affirmation and participation — not of birth, or border, or wealth.

We do not pretend to hold every answer. The hardest questions are written down plainly, and they are the work now before us. But we know enough to begin, and we mean to begin together.

In support of this Declaration, with a firm reliance on one another, we pledge our effort, our good faith, and our names.



A provisional draft — not yet declared, and not yet signed. Offered to everyone who believes there is a better way: to argue with, to improve, and one day to ratify together, community by community.

[**founding signers**]